The Harbor Office

The harbor office stood at the end of the stone pier, a narrow building with blue shutters and a bell that nobody rang anymore. Inside, the shelves held ledgers going back more than a century, each one bound in cloth that had faded to the color of weak tea.

Every morning the clerk unlocked the door, opened the windows, and wrote the date at the top of a fresh page. Some days she recorded a dozen arrivals. Other days the page stayed empty except for the weather, which she noted carefully: wind from the west, light rain, visibility good.

The Box

In the spring, while clearing a cupboard, she found a wooden box tied with string. It held seven small notebooks filled with neat handwriting. They described ships, clouds, and the changing color of the sea, and they were signed only with the initials of the old lighthouse keeper.

She read the first notebook that evening and could not stop. The keeper wrote about storms that lasted three days and about calm nights when the water looked like polished slate. He wrote about a fishing boat that came home late, long after the others, with every lamp on board lit.

By the end of the week she had read them all. She copied her favorite passages into the margins of the harbor ledger, so that anyone who opened it would find a little of the keeper's voice between the dates and the tides.

Visitors

Word spread through the village. People who had never set foot in the harbor office began to visit, asking to see the notebooks. Children traced the drawings of ships with their fingers. An old fisherman sat for an hour with one volume on his knees, reading slowly, and when he left he said that he remembered the night of the late boat.

The clerk started a new ledger just for the visitors. On its first page she wrote a single line: the sea is easier to understand when someone has written it down.